THE GAP

Agents are moving faster than their permissions

Multiple 2026 enterprise reports point to the same blind spot

- 53% of orgs say agents exceeded intended permissions
- 74% say agents get more access than the task needs
- Only 33% have verified their agents are actually scoped right

WHY IT'S SPREADING

Why this is surfacing everywhere right now

Surveys, regulators, and real incidents are all pointing the same direction

- CISA and NSA warned against giving agents broad data access
- NIST flagged agent governance as outpacing existing controls
- Real breaches (e.g. Vercel) trace back to third-party agent access

THE MECHANISM

How agents end up over-permissioned

It's rarely one bad decision, it's a default

- Agents get connected with existing admin or service credentials
- No one scopes access per task, so it's granted broadly upfront
- Permissions are copied from the human workflow, not redesigned

THE BLIND SPOT

Most teams can't see what agents are doing

Visibility is often the real problem, not malice

- 68% can't clearly separate agent actions from human activity
- Monitoring hasn't scaled with the number of agents deployed
- Confidence in access control is high, verification is low

WHAT REGULATORS ARE TELLING US

The guidance is already fairly specific

This isn't theoretical risk management anymore

- Start agents on low-risk tasks before expanding autonomy
- Treat agent identity as distinct from human user identity
- Least-privilege scoping per task, not per system login

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

A practical starting checklist

Before adding another agent, check the basics

- List every system each agent can currently touch
- Scope credentials to the single task, not the whole platform
- Log agent actions separately from human user activity
- Review access monthly, not just at setup

TAKEAWAY

Capability isn't the risk. Access scope is.

The agent doing more isn't the problem, unmanaged reach is

- Treat every new agent like a new employee's access request
- Default to narrow permissions, expand only when justified
- Visibility into agent actions matters as much as the access itself

CTA

What access do your agents actually have?

Most teams haven't audited this yet, worth a look before scaling

- Send me your current agent setup and I'll flag the access gaps
- Happy to compare notes if you're building agent governance now

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